Statement of Teaching Philosophy

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I want future educators and behavior analysts to explain not only how an intervention works, but why it is appropriate for a particular learner. My teaching in special education and applied behavior analysis (ABA) is grounded primarily in Vygotsky's (1978) sociocultural theory, particularly the zone of proximal development. I identify what learners can accomplish independently and calibrate assistance to what they can achieve with support. Scaffolding (Wood et al., 1976) adjusts and gradually withdraws support as competence develops. My applied linguistics background sharpens my attention to how interaction, cultural expectations, and opportunities to communicate shape participation.

Teaching academic writing to international undergraduates at Penn State showed me why assignment sheets alone cannot make expectations visible. Exemplars, guided practice, feedback, and revision help students understand and meet criteria. I organize learning through a sequence: model, practice, feedback, reflect, adapt, and independently apply. Kolb's (1984) experiential learning connects experience with reflection, conceptualization, and experimentation; Schön (1983) guides my attention to reflection during and after practice. In teacher preparation, I model disciplinary reasoning, scaffold rehearsal, and review observed performance. For graduate students and clinical trainees, I would introduce unfamiliar cases requiring justified adaptations rather than procedural reproduction.

These frameworks guide my pedagogy; my RBT experience and BCBA credential ground my clinical perspective in behavioral function, measurement, and data-based adjustment. For children, success includes independent communication and generalization, with assent, choice, and family priorities shaping goals. For adult learners, I would assess both implementation and judgment through observed rehearsals, case analyses, and written rationales. Rubrics would distinguish procedural fidelity, evidence interpretation, ethical justification, and contextual fit. Comparing initial and revised performances would show whether feedback changes decisions, not simply vocabulary. Patterns in student errors and questions also prompt me to revise my explanations and supports. Patience means maintaining clear standards while allowing processing time and repeated opportunities to improve.

In Foundations of Special Education, I asked students to examine common disability myths. Freire's (1970/2000) dialogic pedagogy deepens this activity by asking whose knowledge counts and whose interests instructional goals serve. I would establish discussion agreements, distinguish critique of claims from judgments of people, and invite examination of whether goals support autonomy or merely conformity. Culturally responsive teaching (Gay, 2018) and Universal Design for Learning (CAST, 2024) complement my primary framework: I incorporate learners' cultural knowledge, varied representations, and accessible participation options. Students should not have to disclose personal experiences to contribute, and flexibility in participation should preserve the competencies being assessed.

My research on caregiver-mediated communication interventions for autistic children provides material for interdisciplinary teaching and mentoring. Students could compare single-case findings with caregiver accounts of feasibility, social validity, and family routines, recognizing what each can establish. I would mentor them to refine questions, select methods, and communicate uncertainty with intellectual humility. Across children, teacher candidates, clinicians, and graduate researchers, the shared trajectory is supported participation toward increasingly independent application. My responsibility is to make that progression intentional, assess it transparently, and prepare professionals whose decisions are scientifically grounded, contextually responsive, and ethically defensible.

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